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NAZI-LOOTED ART

Laws trigger fresh legal fight

By Deepa Bharath
The Associated Press

LOS ANGELES» Jewish heirs of Holocaust victims and their representatives have filed two lawsuits in California staking their claims to Nazi-looted paintings that still hang on the walls of prominent museums in Los Angeles and Auschwitz.

This pair of lawsuits are the first to be filed after the recent passage of laws by California and Congress, which strengthen U.S.-based claims to artwork that were taken forcibly from Jewish families during World War II.

One lawsuit was filed in Los Angeles Superior Court on Monday by the Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles and its board chief, Daniel Gryczman, against Norton Simon Museum in Pasadena for the return of "Adam and Eve." These are two life-size, oil-on-panel masterpieces created by Lucas Carnach the Elder in 1530.

The other lawsuit was filed in federal court in Los Angeles the same day by the daughters of the late Dinah Gottliebova Babbitt, a Holocaust survivor and California-based animator who was held in Auschwitz. It demanded the return of watercolors of fellow prisoners that the artist was forced to paint for Josef Mengele, a Nazi physician who had earned the nickname the "Angel of Death."

Spokespersons for both museums say the museums legally hold titles to the works and intend to continue displaying them to the public. The lawsuits don't specify the monetary value of the paintings.

The issue of Nazi-looted art is an emotional and legally and ethically charged topic that pits Jewish families that have suffered inter-generational trauma against museums that say they are trying to preserve a painful yet important, chapter of history. Between 1933 and 1945, the Nazi regime orchestrated the largest art theft in world history, seizing more than 600,000 works of art across Europe from Jewish families, collectors and museums. Decades later, many of these masterpieces reside in prominent museums around the world, making the push for their recovery more complex than a simple property dispute.

Rabbi Noah Farkas is president and CEO of the Jewish Federation of Los Angeles, the organization to which Marei von Saher, sole heir of Dutch Jewish art dealer Jacques Goudstikker, has signed over her rights. The paintings were seized from Goudstikker's collection by Hermann Goring, Adolf Hitler's second-in-command and changed hands before being sold in the 1960s to the Pasadena Museum of Modern Art, which was renamed Norton Simon Museum in honor of its benefactor.

Farkas said the federation plans to use most of the net proceeds from the recovered art to provide much-needed help to the about 2,500 Holocaust survivors living in the Los Angeles area.

"These are incredibly beautiful European masterpieces stolen from a Jewish family to enrich the Nazi party and fund the war and death machine against the people," he said. "It's our honor to take on this role on behalf of the community and use most of the proceeds to help these elderly survivors live out the last years of their lives in dignity, comfort and peace — something their family members were denied during the Holocaust."

Marei von Saher, in a statement, said she is grateful to the Jewish organization for taking up her family's cause.

"This effort represents a meaningful step toward justice for Holocaust survivors and victims of Nazi-era atrocities," she said.

California Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, wrote Assembly Bill 2867, signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom in September 2024, which requires that the state law must apply in lawsuits brought by California residents or their heirs to recover art seized during the Holocaust or during other acts of persecution. Gabriel, a leader of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, introduced the legislation in response to a federal court ruling that allowed the state-owned Thyssen-Bornemisza National Museum in Madrid to keep a multimillion-dollar Camille Pissarro impressionist masterpiece.

That painting had been taken by the Nazis from the Cassirer family in 1939. This case, which prompted this new law, is expected to be heard in federal court in California next month.

Gabriel said it's time for museums to "do some deep introspection on whether they want to be on the right side of history."

TRUMP GREENLAND DEAL

Denmark's leaders cautiously optimistic

By James Brooks and Kirsten Grieshaber
The Associated Press

MADS CLAUS RASMUSSEN — RITZAU SCANPIX VIA AP

From right, Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen; Greenland's prime minister, Jens-Frederik Nielsen; and the Faroe Islands' prime minister, Beinir Johannesen, visit Qooqqut, Greenland, on Sept. 7.

COPENHAGEN, DENMARK» This nation's government was cautiously optimistic Saturday after Donald Trump's announcement of a deal on Greenland to bolster U.S. military presence there but keep the island under Danish control, after months of threats by the U.S. president to seize the semiautonomous territory of a NATO ally.

The Arctic island's top leaders echoed that stance and said the deal, which has not been made public, was long in coming.

U.S., Greenlandic and Danish officials had quietly negotiated for months behind the scenes, searching for solutions to address some of Trump's security concerns about the territory of about 56,000 residents. With the announcement of the pact, Trump is able to tout a foreign policy achievement before the midterm elections in the United States.

Trump said Friday that the agreement would give the U.S. "permanent control over security, and all other needs, in Greenland, completely addressing ALL of our many U.S. concerns."

Denmark and the U.S. already have a long-standing security agreement that allows the U.S. to deploy forces in Greenland, and it was not immediately clear how this deal would be different from that.

"I think it's obvious that we can expect more bases in Greenland. But it's important to say that if we look in the past, especially during the Cold War, the U.S. had immense military presence in Greenland," said Marc Jacobsen, an associate professor at the Royal Danish Defense College and the head of research at the Center for Arctic Security Studies.

He said it was a win for Trump. "It's important for him to show that he's a good businessman, that he kind of forced the pressure on Denmark and Greenland into something new."

After Trump's announcement, the office of Denmark's prime minister, Mette Frederiksen, said the deal will be signed next week at the United Nations General Assembly. Parliamentary action was still needed by the Danish and Greenlandic governments before it can be enforced, she added.

"Next week could be a good week … for Greenland, Denmark, and the United States alike," Danish Foreign Minister Lars Løkke Rasmussen wrote on Instagram on Saturday morning.

"A period of uncertainty will hopefully be replaced by a binding agreement that strengthens security in the Arctic and the North Atlantic — and thus also our shared security within NATO and Europe," he added.

Greenland's government leader, Jens-Frederik Nielsen, said the deal would benefit "not only our collective security, but also the continued development here in the country."

The island's foreign minister, Múte B. Egede, said he was pleased "we now have an agreement within reach."

"I'm pleased that we finally have an end product within reach," he told Denmark's TV2 broadcaster. "It's about time."

Adm. Giuseppe Cavo Dragone, chair of the NATO Military Committee, said later Saturday in the Danish capital that the agreement was "very, very welcome," without commenting on it further.

Trump said that with the agreement, the U.S. would "immediately" begin the process of developing a larger military presence on the mineral-rich Danish territory.

The U.S. had held several bases and installations on Greenland through the Cold War, before dialing back its presence. It still operates the remote Pituffik Space Base in northwestern Greenland, built after the U.S. and Denmark signed the Defense of Greenland Treaty in 1951.

The base supports missile warning, missile defense and space surveillance operations for the U.S. and NATO.

NARGES MOHAMMADI

Nobel laureate speaks on Iranians' suffering

By Amir-Hussein Radjy
The Associated Press

Iranians are suffering as economic misery and internal repression leave "no room for people to breathe" after 1½ years of wars, Iran's most prominent human rights activist told The Associated Press.

Narges Mohammadi, 54, who was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 2023, was released from prison temporarily for medical reasons this year after falling unconscious and being transferred to a hospital.

Her memoir — titled "A Woman Never Stops Fighting" — was written behind bars, with parts of it smuggled out by fellow inmates. Editions in French, German and nine other languages are being released this month. The English and Farsi editions will be released next year.

In an interview conducted Friday by The Associated Press from outside Iran, Mohammadi said that Iranians are grappling with multiple crises stemming from the ongoing war and deepening economic pressure and the brutal crackdowns on protests.

"I am sorry to say, but since the outbreak of war, in the past months and last year and a half, we have seen that repression in society has severely increased and now, with these economic pressures and with the repression that really has left no room for people to breathe, it's the people who are paying an extremely heavy price," she said.

But she said that many Iranians continue to resist, a change she traces back to the 2022 protests over the death of Mahsa Amini, a 22-year-old woman who died in a hospital after being detained for violating authorities' strict Islamic dress code.

The release of Mohammadi's book this month coincides with Amini's death to honor her memory, her representatives said. The English and Farsi editions will be released in September 2027 for the same reason.

"If you go out into the streets, you see a wave of resistance among the people, a wave of awareness, and their determination to stand up for their rights," Mohammadi said. She said that government repression has intensified, but that many in a new younger generation "know their rights" and were standing firm. "And that gives us reason for hope," she said.

The AP agreed not to ask Mohammadi specific questions about the political situation and leadership in Iran, because of concerns for her safety, although she commented generally about the cost of war.

In her interview with the AP, Mohammadi — who has been jailed repeatedly over decades of advocating for human rights and was behind bars when she was awarded the Nobel Prize — described her most recent arrest, detention and health.

She said that she was beaten severely by security forces when detained in December, in the northeastern city of Mashhad. She and a group of activists were attending a memorial ceremony for human rights lawyer Khosrow Alikordi, who was found dead in his office.

She was arrested while giving a public speech. She was sentenced to 7½ years for attending that rally. She is now facing a total of 16 years and more than 100 lashes. She hasn't been flogged but spent long periods in solitary confinement.

"My detention was really life-threatening," she said. "My head was severely hurt, because most of the hits were to my head, and despite being in that condition, they kept me for two months in solitary confinement during which my condition was really concerning."

She lost consciousness on May 1 and was released on bail nearly 10 days later and transferred to a hospital in Tehran, where she remained for two weeks.

In brief

BUSINESS

Lawsuit: Firms made illegal agreement on AI slowdown

A new lawsuit claims Anthropic, OpenAI, SpaceXAI and Google made an illegal deal to slow the pace of their respective AI development.

The lawsuit, which was filed Friday in U.S. District Court for the northern California, argues that the leading AI companies violated antitrust laws when they agreed to coordinate slowdown efforts and that doing so would reduce the value consumers get for paid AI subscriptions.

The coordination largely took place Sept. 12, the lawsuit argues, when Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei published an essay urging for industry-wide cooperation on decelerating advancements in favor of enhanced safety measures. That same day, OpenAI CEO Sam Altman, SpaceXAI CEO Elon Musk and Google DeepMind's co-founder and chair Demis Hassabis each publicly responded to Amodei's proposals in agreement.

But the lawsuit also alleges that the coordination began to take shape months earlier. It points to a statement from July that high-ranking employees from several of the leading AI labs signed that acknowledged the "intense competitive pressure not to unilaterally slow" development. That statement called on the government to support a global effort to slow automated AI development.

ISRAEL

President pardons combat medic whose shooting of attacker caused debate

Israel's president on Saturday pardoned the combat medic who shot dead at close range a badly wounded Palestinian attacker who had stabbed a soldier in the occupied West Bank, a case that divided the country a decade ago.

Elor Azaria's conviction in 2017 for manslaughter and his release after serving two-thirds of his 18-month sentence drew enormous attention in Israel, where military service is compulsory for most Jewish men. In his first interview after his release, Azaria said, "I would act exactly the same, because that's how I needed to act."

Azaria had approached Abdel Fattah al-Sharif as he lay on the ground, unarmed and badly hurt, after stabbing a soldier in the city of Hebron. A cellphone video captured Azaria shooting al-Sharif in the head.

The office of President Isaac Herzog said in a statement that he acted on the recommendation of Defense Minister Israel Katz.

EBOLA OUTBREAK

Congo begins vaccinations for healthcare workers

Congo on Saturday began vaccinating healthcare staffers against Ebola in Bunia, the epicenter of the fastest-growing outbreak of the disease in history as they are "particularly exposed and deeply involved in the response," the provincial governor said.

Health workers and other front-line workers in the Ebola response are being prioritized to receive the Ervebo vaccine that was effective in past Ebola outbreaks caused by a different, more common type of virus. Clinical trials are ongoing to find a licensed vaccine for the current outbreak, caused by the Bundibugyo virus, which has no licensed vaccine or treatment.

The rollout is targeting the Bunia and Mongbwalu zones in Ituri province, health authorities said Saturday. Both areas are among the hardest-hit by the virus.

PAKISTAN

Forces end 20-hour standoff with militants

Pakistani security forces on Saturday ended a standoff with militants holed up inside a police compound in northwestern Pakistan, officials said.

The confrontation began Friday after a suicide bomber rammed an explosives-laden vehicle into a mosque, and gunmen stormed the facility, killing 21 people and wounding 103.

The coordinated attack occurred at a compound in Kohat, in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, which borders Afghanistan.

Many of the casualties were police officers and people attending prayers at a mosque.

— Denver Post news services

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